



2 Guided literary analysis: unseen poetry (Paper 1)

Paper 1 · Guided literary analysis · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

The poetry option in Paper 1 requires close analysis of an unseen poem in response to a guiding question, attending to how form (lineation, stanza shape, rhyme, metre), sound (rhythm, assonance, consonance) and figurative language combine to create meaning. Because poems compress meaning into fewer words, every formal choice — including line breaks and white space — should be treated as a deliberate, analysable decision rather than decoration.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Guiding question: how does the poet convey a sense of loss? Model line of analysis: 'The poem's short, end-stopped final line, 'and that was all,' breaks abruptly from the longer, enjambed lines that precede it, so the sudden contraction in line length enacts the finality of loss at the level of form, not just statement.' This connects a specific formal feature (line length change) to the guiding question rather than simply paraphrasing content.

Quick check · multiple choice

In poetry analysis, enjambment (a sentence or clause running over a line break without punctuation) most typically creates which effect?

A A hard stop that isolates a single word for emphasis

B A forward momentum or sense of continuation that can mirror urgency, flow, or unresolved thought

C A strict adherence to a regular rhyme scheme

D A change in the poem's narrative point of view

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Read the following invented four-line extract and respond to the guiding question: [20]
How does the poet use form and sound to convey a feeling of restlessness? 'The kettle clicks off but the room keeps humming, / a low note caught between the walls and the clock, / and I am still standing where the light left me, / waiting for a silence that will not walk in.' Write a close analysis addressing the guiding question, considering sound, enjambment, and imagery.

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

Introduction: thesis that restlessness is conveyed through sustained sound imagery and unresolved syntax rather than explicit statement of feeling.

- Point 1: the personified 'silence that will not walk in' inverts expectation (silence should simply be absent, not withheld), suggesting the speaker's disquiet outlasts the literal noise.
- Point 2: assonance and consonance ('humming', 'low note') create a lingering aural texture that mimics the persistence of unease after the kettle's action ends.
- Point 3: enjambment across all four lines withholds syntactic closure until the final line, mirroring the speaker's own suspended, waiting state.
- Point 4: the shift from an external sound (kettle, hum) to an internal state ('waiting') tracks restlessness moving from environment to psychology.
- Conclusion: emphasise that form (withheld closure) enacts the theme (restlessness) rather than merely describing it.

Quick check answer

B. Enjambment carries meaning across the line break, often creating momentum, tension, or a sense that a thought is unresolved until the next line.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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